Headley returned to Pakistan and in August Major Iqbal visited him at home, bringing $25,000 to be used for surveillance work. A separate meeting with his Lashkar handler, Sajid Mir, followed in Muzaffarabad and in September Headley departed on his first trip to India. Using the money given to him by Iqbal, he opened an immigration office and even hired a secretary. Headley also began taking photographs of various potential targets, including the Taj. He returned to Pakistan in December and met separately with Iqbal in Lahore and Sajid in Muzaffarabad to brief them. This pattern repeated itself on numerous occasions and it is notable that Headley always met his ISI and Lashkar handlers separately, delivering to each their own customized photographs or video recordings.[95] Sajid was very interested in the Taj Hotel, and particularly in an annual conference of software professionals held there. However, there was no specific discussion of targeting the hotel at this point and Headley did not perceive any immediate plans for a strike. Rather, Lashkar seems to have been at the information gathering stage. Meanwhile, Headley continued training with the NCO detailed to him by Iqbal.[96]

Following another round of meetings with his ISI and Lashkar handlers respectively, Headley returned to Mumbai in February 2007. He continued photographing various sites and making video recordings, while also making unscheduled trips to Pakistan on one occasion and to Dubai on another without telling his handlers. He made a scheduled return to Pakistan in June, and met first with Iqbal and then Sajid, giving each a memory stick with surveillance footage. Headley met with them again before traveling back to India in September. By this stage he was receiving more specific instructions from each, but his marching orders did not overlap. Major Iqbal provided him with counterfeit Indian currency and directed him to conduct surveillance in the city of Pune. Sajid was ‘very clear in his mind’: he wanted extensive reconnaissance of the Taj, which had become a potential target for attack. Headley said that, during his time in Pakistan, he and Sajid often discussed striking the hotel during the aforementioned annual conference of software professionals. Lashkar had focused on economic targets since the early years of the decade, and this fit neatly within those confines. The aim was to infiltrate one or two fidayeen into India via Nepal or Bangladesh, strike the Taj and then exfiltrate them somehow; a plan not dissimilar in motive or operational scope from the 2005 attack on the Indian Institute of Science in Bangalore.[97]